

## **The Image of the Mountain as Spiritual Ascent in Ancient Near Eastern, Zoroastrian and Abrahamic Traditions**

I may not end up using all of these sources and narrow them further, but here is a tentative list of references. If you have any suggestions for useful readings that I may be missing, I would love to hear them.

I want to investigate metaphysical inheritance and conceptual continuity from the Ancient Near East to the Abrahamic religions. I am particularly drawn to the symbology of the mountain as axis mundi and an image of ascent and return to God. This teleological chain of being is compressed in images like the mountain, but can also be found analogously in the exile narrative.

### **Primary Sources**

- *Enuma Elish*: Babylonian creation myth that was inherited by the Hebrews in the form of the Genesis cosmological account. This lays the foundation for later metaphysical refinement of a hierarchically-ordered cosmos. Contains a description of a cosmic temple that serves as a type for Mount Zion.
- *Ugaritic Baal Cycle*: Canaanite myth cycle following Baal's quest to establish dominion over the cosmos. Attaining victory, Baal builds a palace on Mount Zaphon, prefiguring Mount Zion.
- *Exodus, Psalms, Ezekiel, Enoch, Matthew, Revelation*.
- *The Quran*
- *Avesta, Bundahishn*. Zoroastrian scriptures that contain a description of a cosmology centered around a mountain.
- Plato, *Timaeus*. Plato's most complete description of his cosmology; describes a chaotic universe being set to order by the Demiurge, governed by physical laws. This writing introduces a hierarchical and layered chain of being descended from the Forms. Had great influence on later Christian thinking.
- Plotinus, *Enneads*. Plotinus develops Plato's hierarchical cosmology further, introducing the emanationist idea that all being descends from the One by degrees. Emanationist thinking is important in Abrahamic mysticism broadly, spiritual progress being conceived as an upwards and 'backwards' (teleological) traversal to God.
- Gregory of Nyssa, *The Life of Moses*. This text introduces the idea of the spiritual life as an ascent of a mountain to Christian mysticism, drawing on Neoplatonic thought.
- Pseudo-Dionysius, *The Celestial Hierarchy, Mystical Theology*. Further refines Plotinus' hierarchy of being, also showing Zoroastrian influence in its hierarchies of angels and the church.
- Maximus the Confessor, *Mystagogia, Ambigua*. Maximus the Confessor is a crucial contributor to Orthodox theology. He develops the teleological chain of being into a full cosmology of angels and spirits. Important for Aquinas' discussion in *Summa Theologiae*.
- Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae*. Contains a section discussing a hierarchically-ordered cosmos and the role of angels.

- Dante Alighieri, *Divine Comedy*. Purgatorio is a literary exposition of the mountain idea.

## Secondary Sources

- Mircea Eliade, *Patterns in Comparative Religion* (1949). Contains a discussion of the significance of mountains in religious symbolism. Discussing the axis mundi, mountains come to represent the center of the world, where the divine and human worlds meet. According to Eliade, mountains are related to sky deities in the sense that they represent the transcendent, the sacred, or the distance between the transcendent and humanity. The ascent of the mountain is the human's path to the divine.
- Mircea Eliade, *The Sacred and the Profane* (1957).
- Mircea Eliade, *Images and Symbols* (1952).
- Henry Corbin, *Temple and Contemplation* (1986). Contains essays discussing the mountain and temple as symbols of the human soul in the Abrahamic faiths. Discusses the role of the temple, mountain and soul as axis mundi.
- Henry Corbin, *Spiritual Body and Celestial Earth* (1977). Discusses the mountain as an archetype of spiritual ascent in mystical Islam. Here, too, the mountain functions as a sort of axis mundi.
- Henry Corbin, *History of Islamic Philosophy* (1964).
- John Walton, *Ancient Near Eastern Thought and the Old Testament* (2006). Discusses the relationship of Near Eastern cosmologies to later Abrahamic faiths. Focuses on the image of the mountain as axis mundi and emphasizes Israelite reinterpretation of earlier Near Eastern myths in the context of monotheism.
- Gershom Scholem, *On the Mystical Shape of the Godhead* (1962). Focuses on esoteric Judaism and the metaphysical structure of divinity in the faith. Mirrors Neoplatonist accounts in the ascent through the Sephirot, but in a specifically Biblical context.
- René Guénon, *Symbols of Sacred Science* (1962). Brief discussion of esoteric, symbological interpretation of the mountain and the cave.
- Arthur Lovejoy, *The Great Chain of Being* (1936). A history of the hierarchical chain of being in Christian faith that underlies the mountain motif.
- Seyyed Hossein Nasr (ed.), *Religion and the Order of Nature* (1996). Another history of the chain of being.
- William Chittick, *The Sufi Path of Knowledge* (1989).